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Thomistic Seminar

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From Happiness to Well-Being

Morning Session

Prof. Jennifer Frey

Readings:

Well-Being as Value Fulfillment, *Ch. 2*

Valerie Tiberius

Finite and Infinite Goods: A Framework for Ethics, *Ch. 3*

Robert Merrihew Adams



Well-Being as Value Fulfillment: How We Can Help Each Other to Live Well

Valerie Tiberius

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CHAPTER

2 The Value Fulfillment Theory of Well-Being

Valerie Tiberius

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Abstract

According to the value fulfillment theory, our lives go well to the extent that we pursue, and fulfill or realize, our appropriate values. This chapter focuses on what values are, how they can be improved, and why we should consider them over time. To value something in the fullest sense is to have a relatively stable pattern of emotions and desires with respect to it and to take these attitudes to give you reasons for action and (for the most important values) standards for evaluating how your life is going. Appropriate values, then, are the objects of relatively sustainable and integrated emotions, desires, and judgments.

Keywords: values, valuing, appropriateness, emotion, desire, judgment, psychological integration, development, fulfillment, success

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2.1 Main Features of the Value Fulfillment Theory

According to the value fulfillment theory, our lives go well to the extent that we pursue, and fulfill or realize, our appropriate values. In short, we live well when we succeed in terms of what matters to us emotionally, reflectively, and over the long term.¹ This includes achieving certain states of affairs (such as career goals) and also maintaining the positive emotional orientation that comprises valuing something. If your values include your own enjoyment, relationships with family and friends, accomplishing something in your career, and contributing to certain morally worthwhile projects, then your life goes well for you insofar as you have good relationships and career success, make a moral contribution, and enjoy what you're doing, as long as these continue to be the things you care about. (These are common values for human beings, but if you have different values, and those values are appropriate for you, your well-being will look different—more on these differences later.)

p. 35 Your life goes badly to the degree that you live a life that has little value fulfillment. This can happen because you find no value in anything, because what you disvalue comes to pass, because your values are thwarted by external obstacles, or because your values are difficult to fulfill together over time. This last problem can be caused by values that are in conflict with each other, or values that do not suit you. ↪ (This is a very rough description of “ill-being”—more deserves to be said, but a full theory of ill-being according to the value fulfillment theory would require a book of its own. I will say a little more about it in Section 3.2.) People who are significantly depressed and whose affective capacities are dampened do not fare well (according to the value fulfillment theory), because they have trouble finding value in their projects and relationships. People who suffer material deprivation or loss of loved ones do not fare well because their values are threatened by the world. People who have values that create obstacles to health, happiness, or psychological harmony, do not fare well because they have values that conflict with other values that are (in most cases) essential to a set of values that can be fulfilled successfully over time.

There are, then, three main parts of the value fulfillment theory: values, fulfillment, and time. We'll discuss each of these components in more detail shortly, but let's start with an overview that goes a little deeper than the one I provided in the introduction. First, to value something in the fullest sense is to have a relatively stable pattern of emotions and desires with respect to it and to take these attitudes to give you reasons for action and (for the most important values) standards for evaluating how your life is going. If you value your job, then you will want to do well at it and to have time for it; you will be disposed to enjoy what you do, to feel proud when you get promoted, and disappointed when you don't do your best work; when you reflect on how your life is going you will tend to think about how you are doing in your work as relevant to this question and you'll tend to take your job into account when you're making plans for the future. Valuing, therefore, has an affective, a conative, and a cognitive dimension—it involves our emotions, our desires, and our judgment—and values are the objects of these valuing attitudes.² Because values have these dimensions, our values themselves can be more or less appropriate for us; that is, they can be more or less suited to our emotions and desires, and more or less aligned with our judgments about what's good.³ Appropriate values are the objects of relatively sustainable and integrated emotions, desires, and judgments.

p. 36 What it is for a value to be fulfilled and what it means to say that one life has more value fulfillment than another are obviously very important for the theory I'm proposing. Values, like desires, bring with them standards of success, and living up to these standards is the essence of value fulfillment. In the example above, it's easy to see how valuing one's job entails standards of success or fulfillment: whatever counts as doing well at your job fulfills that value. But standards for values are not always obvious. Some values—such as the value of honesty or integrity—are such that we succeed in their terms by having the right attitudes or being a certain kind of person. Nevertheless, there are standards for values in the sense that there are ways of responding appropriately or inappropriately given the nature of what is valued (Anderson 1995). Moreover, most values encompass standards that are objective in the sense that whether or not we fulfill them is not a matter of whether we believe we are fulfilling them. There is something to meeting the standards that our values impose that goes beyond our subjective experience. In this respect, value fulfillment is similar to preference satisfaction: you may fail to get what you want without knowing it (say, if you are seriously deluded), and you may fail to fulfill your values, though you believe otherwise. Finally, if we are going to achieve what matters to us, it is not only success in terms of what is valued that matters, but also the valuing attitudes themselves. We require some stability in our valuing attitudes if we are going to succeed by the standards we think are important. (Of course, there is such a thing as too much stability: how much stability is required, and when change is recommended, are difficult practical questions, as we will see in later chapters.) Value fulfillment, then, requires succeeding by the standards of that value while continuing to think that these standards are important to how well your life goes.

Assessing *overall* value fulfillment requires attending to the relationships between values and their development over time. People typically have numerous values of different kinds and degrees of importance.

p. 37 We value some things largely as a means to others (for example, you might value running marathons as a means to ↪ the values of health and fitness). We value some things as specific expressions of other more abstract things (for example, you might value playing the piano *as a way of* valuing music). Some values are more important to us than others and some values have a more central role in the whole system. Further, values develop. Our basic values probably don't change much, but we do change how we understand their fulfillment and how they are prioritized. These considerations must be taken into account when we evaluate overall value fulfillment and we ask whether choosing one path over another promises more overall value fulfillment.

We can now proceed to fill in the details. The remainder of this chapter will focus on what values are, how they can be improved, and why we should consider them over time. In Chapter 3 we'll turn to fulfillment.

2.2 What are Values?

Values are defined in various ways for different purposes. Because we are looking for a characterization of values that can play a central role in a theory that captures the special relationship of well-being to the subject (the way in which well-being is supposed to be good *for* the person), we will do best to understand values by reference to the activity of valuing. What can we say about the activity of valuing?

First, intuitively, to value something is to care about it in a particular way, and to care about something is to have particular feelings and desires with respect to it.⁴ Other things equal, we are motivated to pursue or promote the values to which we are committed and we are disposed to react emotionally when these values are helped or threatened. For example, a mother who values being a parent wants to spend time with her child and is relatively robustly disposed to enjoy that time. She is disposed to feel proud when her child tells her she's a great mom, to be ashamed when she forgets to pick her child up from school, and so on.⁵

p. 38 Second, to value something, and not merely to prefer it or like it, is to judge that it is the kind of thing that is good in some way. To put ↪ the point in terms that are common in philosophy, we take our values to generate *reasons* for us (reasons to respond in certain ways and not others), and to be the sort of thing we should consider in our planning and evaluation of how our lives are going.⁶ Our exemplary mother takes her being a parent to justify certain decisions and plans she makes for her life, including decisions that require sacrificing other things she wants. She takes 'being a good parent' to be highly relevant to how well her life is going. The particular standards we have for how to value something in a fitting way are influenced by cultural expectations and norms, and by the emotions that are included in our valuing attitudes. For example, someone who values being a parent is likely to think that attending to her child's needs is a standard for valuing parenthood in a fitting way; if you habitually don't notice your child's needs, you are failing to value parenthood (and your child). We'll talk more about these standards when we talk about value *fulfillment*. For now, the important point is that when we *value* something as opposed to merely wanting it, we take it to give us reasons that are relevant to how we shape our lives. We might put the point this way: Appropriate values are "reflectively endorsed" (though the word "reflectively" should not be taken to imply anything too extravagant or intellectual).⁷

These observations about valuing lead to a view according to which valuing is a complex pattern of attitudes; it includes emotion, desire, and judgment. This is not the standard view in philosophy. Philosophers who write about valuing tend to fall into two camps: those who take valuing to be equivalent to desiring (Lewis 2000; Railton 2003); and those who take it to be equivalent to believing or judging that something is valuable (Dorsey 2012; Korsgaard 1996; Smith 1995). There may be reasons for wanting a more streamlined characterization of valuing when it comes to articulating a metaethical position, but for our purposes, these simpler characterizations are unnecessary and inadequate. Values that harmonize our emotions, desires, and judgments are a better focus for a theory of well-being, because we do better at meeting our aims when our

p. 39 emotions, desires, and judgments are more integrated.⁸ Conflict creates obstacles to success. Anyone who has tried to start an exercise program or change their diet has likely had the experience of recalcitrant desires and emotions in conflict with judgments about what to do. As we all know, such conflicts make it more difficult to succeed. Recalcitrant *judgments* are also possible—think of the person raised in the Church of the Nazarene, who loves dancing and wants to dance professionally more than anything else, but who can’t shake the belief that dancing is sinful.

This multifaceted understanding of values also helps to make sense of the way we tend to talk about values. We tend to be less confident in attributing values to people who lack the affective or the cognitive dimension of valuing and more confident saying that a person values something when they have both components in a relatively stable way. For example, which man more clearly *values* his marriage: the one who loves his wife, but believes he should have been a priest and never have married, or the one who both loves his wife and believes his marriage to be a good thing? Which person more obviously counts as *valuing* music? The woman who plays the piano because she believes it is good for her or the woman who believes it is good for her and loves it? It seems to me the compelling answer in both cases is the second option. When the person’s emotions and judgments track together in favor of something, there’s nothing to make us skeptical about whether they *value* that thing. Making a judgment about the goodness of something or having an emotional attachment to it are each evidence for valuing, but valuing—in the sense best suited for the value fulfillment theory—includes both.⁹

Values in which desire, emotion, and judgment are perfectly harmonized may not be the norm—we do live with a lot of conflict—but that’s OK for the purpose of thinking about how to improve people’s lives. Values that integrate our desires, emotions, and judgments are an ideal to aspire to. When we talk about a person’s actual values we will have to make a judgment call about how much the person’s attitudes represent valuing. There are practical reasons to take people’s word for it by just allowing them to tell us what they value, but this
p. 40 needn’t prevent us from noticing that what they say they value does not line up well with what they actually want, like, or approve. As we’ll see, lack of integration leaves room for improvement.

Values, then, in the specialized sense required by the value fulfillment theory, are patterns of relatively robust desires and emotions that we endorse as giving us reasons relevant to planning and evaluating our lives.¹⁰ I mean to be very inclusive about what counts: people can value activities, relationships, other creatures (human or otherwise), character traits, goals, ideals, principles, and so on, and so all of these things can count as values. I’ll also talk about “instrumental values” (things we value as a means to other values) and “ultimate values” (things we value at least in part for their own sakes); instrumental values can contribute to well-being, though their contribution will depend on the value of the end to which they are a means.

There is one more important feature of values to discuss, which has to do with how they work together. Values form systems of mutual reinforcement and integration that help or hinder their fulfillment. Some values will be more “core” than others in the sense that they are used more often in explanations of the importance of other values. For example, the value of (psychological) happiness is likely to be a core value for many because it will be appealed to in explaining what is important about other values such as sports, hobbies, and friendships. I do not assume that values occupy a rigid hierarchy (though they may for some people); rather, values are more likely to be arranged in a web of mutual support with some values more centrally located than others. Notice that some values are purely instrumental (the value of money is usually like this), which means that these things are valued only as a means to something else. Many things are valued partly for their own sakes and partly as a means to something else. A good friendship, for example, may be valued for itself and also because it brings happiness. Even ultimate values can vary in degrees of centrality; happiness may explain the value of more instrumental values than, say, a particular friendship though both are valued (in part) for their own sakes. Further, the means–end relationship is not the only way in which values are related to each other. For
p. 41 instance, some values are expressions of other, more abstractly described values. A person who values music may value playing the piano as a *way* of valuing music. In this case playing the piano is valued intrinsically, not

as a means to appreciating music; the piano player does not value a distinct musical good that is caused by playing the piano.

Now, we sometimes say that we value something when we care about it, but don't have terribly robust judgments about its value for us, and we sometimes say we value things when our emotions are not quite aligned. Further, especially when taken together, our values can be unsustainable, impossible to fulfill together over time. Value fulfillment is imperiled by serious conflict among core values, poor connections between instrumental and ultimate values, or dysfunctional ways of interpreting the standards of success for our values. There are ways that values can fall short of the rather ideal picture I've described; actual values vary in appropriateness, and not all of the values people claim to have will exhibit this kind of psychological harmony. We can say, then, that *appropriate* values are (1) suited to our desires and emotions, (2) reflectively endorsed, and (3) capable of being fulfilled together over time. In other words, as I put it in the previous chapter, appropriate values are the objects of relatively sustainable and integrated emotions, desires, and judgments.

p. 42 Three qualifications are in order. First, I mentioned that there are ultimate values and instrumental values. We value some things (like friendship, health, and meaningful work) for their own sakes and others (money, healthcare, and a college diploma) as a means to something more ultimate. I don't think the line between ultimate and instrumental values is always a bright one for people. Do you value physical health for its own sake or for its contribution to your ability to do everything you want to do? It's hard to say, and people surely differ about this. One reason it can be hard to say is that values can be mixed. Health may be something we value both for its own sake and as a means to other things. Another reason it's hard to say is that we don't have ready vocabularies for explaining why we value something for its own sake, which makes us reach for some further, more ultimate value. As we'll see as we go along, I don't think it matters $\hookrightarrow$ very much where the line is drawn. It does matter that some goals we have are so clearly instrumental that it starts to strain the notion of "value" to call them values. For example, I aim to floss my teeth regularly to avoid gum disease, and ultimately for the sake of my physical health. It would be odd to say that I *value* flossing my teeth (even though it is something about which I have stable desires and judgments that figure into my planning!); it's just too trivial. When this happens, I think it's more natural to talk about desiring the means to a more ultimate value, and that's what I'll do.

Second, people have moral values. Most of us value being a basically morally decent person, and failing to be morally decent would be a failure to thrive from our own point of view. Moral commitments like these are easy to mesh with the value fulfillment theory of well-being; we fare well when we fulfill a variety of values, including moral ones. But not all moral commitments are like this; sometimes moral values seem to be at odds with well-being. This leads to a well-known problem for the value fulfillment theory and theories like it (desire satisfactionism, for instance). This is the problem of self-sacrifice, which is that if well-being is getting what we want or value, it seems that it is conceptually impossible to sacrifice our own interests for the sake of a moral goal that we also want or value (Overvold 1980). In other words, the worry is that the value fulfillment theory rules out moral sacrifice by definition, and this seems wrong. For example, consider Dahlia, who cares, more than anything, about saving other people from the devastating effects of climate change. Dahlia therefore decides to devote her life to lobbying the U.S. government to approve stronger fossil fuel regulations, and she throws herself into this work with an intensity that leaves no room for anything else. It could seem that as long as Dahlia is successful in terms of this goal, her life is going well according to the value fulfillment theory even if she herself regards her choices as sacrificing her own good for the sake of others.

p. 43 Moral sacrifice may be psychologically difficult, but it shouldn't be made conceptually impossible by a theory of well-being. Fortunately, the value fulfillment theory is not saddled with this result. Recall that $\hookrightarrow$ what matters to well-being as value fulfillment is the overall amount of fulfillment of values that are emotionally, motivationally, and cognitively suited to the person. So, one thing we can say is that Dahlia may be sacrificing more value fulfillment of this kind over the long run if the stress of her work shortens her life or leaves her burned out, exhausted, and unable to attain much value fulfillment in the second half of her life.¹¹ A person

who literally sacrifices her life for a moral cause is naturally described in this way: even if that person values the moral cause and nothing else, she sacrifices her own well-being by forgoing all future value fulfillment. Similarly, if Dahlia forgoes having children and spending time with friends, and if the work she does for climate justice ends up not succeeding terribly well, she may eventually relinquish greater value fulfillment over the long term even though working for climate justice is what she values most at this moment.

But what if these “ifs” aren’t true of Dahlia? What if she is psychologically organized in such a way that she would not gain greater value fulfillment by pursuing a life with a greater diversity of values? What if she’s just the rather unusual, slightly obsessive sort of person for whom the addition of fun, friendship, and time spent with her family, would not increase her overall value fulfillment? The value fulfillment theory implies that *this* Dahlia would not sacrifice her own well-being by devoting herself to the moral cause. But now this doesn’t seem like such a bad result. If Dahlia continues to enjoy her work and doesn’t come to value things that are incompatible with her choices, then it is not so unintuitive to say that she is doing what is best for her. As Heathwood (2011) says in his defense of desire satisfactionism against the problem of self-sacrifice, the claim that Dahlia is sacrificing well-being for a moral cause “appears rather question-begging”. Just because Dahlia “isn’t acting with herself, or with her own best interests in mind, and is instead acting benevolently for others, we cannot conclude that she must therefore fail to be doing what is in her best interests” (p. 35).

p. 44 There’s one more thing to say about moral values, which is that not all moral ideals are values in the sense relevant to the value fulfillment theory. As I said above, the relevant values for well-being are endorsed as the kind of thing we should consider in our planning and evaluation of how our lives are going. Not all of our moral ideals are so directly practical: we see the moral importance of ending injustice, but we don’t think it translates into a full-time job for us. Personally, I’m deeply committed to the wrongness of slavery and torture, but these commitments do not come into play in my life as a philosophy professor very often (except maybe in my choice of topics to discuss in ethics classes). (Of course, these commitments *could become* be more directly relevant to how I live my life; things could take a turn for the much worse and then everyone would be called upon to prioritize these commitments in action.) So, moral ideals and commitments are not always values in the sense that is relevant to well-being as value fulfillment. This point does not help much with the problem of self-sacrifice, though, because moral ideals that are not taken to be practical will not be ones that people make sacrifices for in the first place. Still, it is worth noting that not everything that might fall under the label “value” is a value in the sense relevant to the value fulfillment theory.

The third qualification is that people also disvalue. Often there are positive correlates to our disvalues. I hate meanness and pettiness, but these negative attitudes are part of valuing kindness and generosity. Part of what it is to value kindness and generosity, in other words, is to be disposed to negative emotions toward the vices that express their absence. Sometimes our disvalues are instrumental to things we value. I disvalue military museums and naval history. I am very consistently disposed to avoid them, to feel bored and miserable when I’m exposed to them, and to take them not to contribute to a good life for me. In this case, I disvalue these things because I regard them as a hindrance to things I value intrinsically (my happiness, for instance). There are also things we disvalue for their own sakes, as it were. Pain, for instance, is something most people are disposed to abhor, desire not to experience, and take to be a relevant consideration in planning and decision-making.¹²

p. 45 Values, in the sense relevant to the value fulfillment theory, are complex psychological states that come in degrees (some may be more emotionally entrenched than others, for example). Many of our actual values, especially our basic, core values, are appropriate: they involve our desires and emotions, we use them to plan and deliberate, and they are part of sustainable systems of values. That said, the values we have are not *necessarily* appropriate and there are some things we should value even if we don’t claim to.¹³ For example, it follows from what I’ve said that health and happiness are appropriate values for most people, even though it isn’t necessarily the case that people would put these at the top of their list if you asked them to enumerate their values. It may be that people wouldn’t mention health and happiness if asked because they are taking

them for granted at the moment. Nevertheless, emotional dispositions, desires, and tendencies to take health and happiness in account in your decision-making contribute significantly to a stable system of values that can be fulfilled over time. I'll say more about the ways in which values can be assessed as better or worse in the next section, and even more in the next chapter.

With this account of values in hand, we can return to the question I posed in the previous chapter: If we are contemplating a theory of well-being that starts with the agent's own point of view, why focus on values rather than desires, say, or life satisfaction? My answer is that values just are the part of a person's own point of view that they take to determine how well their life goes. People identify themselves in terms of their values more readily than they do in terms of their desires, and values are of particular importance to people from their own point of view. Further, because values are complex psychological patterns, they are better able to explain the various ways in which we can go wrong when it comes to well-being.¹⁴ We sometimes challenge or change our view about what is good for us in the light of judgments about what is worth valuing. For instance, a person (like Maxine from Chapter 1) who discovers she cannot conceive a child might reconsider how important biological connection is to the real value of being a mother and she might decide that it would be best for her to adopt. We also challenge judgments about what is good for us on the basis of our emotional responses: we may realize just how much something $\hookrightarrow$ matters to us because we notice that we feel bad when it is taken away from us, or elated when it comes back into our lives (Stocker 1990). When this happens we learn from our feelings that there are things about our well-being of which we were not aware. Because values have these different dimensions, they are well suited to explain how both types of change constitute improvements to our views about what is good for us.

In short, values embody our own view of what's worth seeking in a way that mere preferences or life satisfaction judgments do not, and this gives the theory an advantage (over these other theories) in accommodating the sense in which well-being is supposed to be something good.¹⁵

2.3 The Value-Fulfilled Life and the Long-Term Perspective

Well-being, I have said, is the fulfillment of appropriate values over time; it is a *life* rich in value fulfillment. This makes it seem like the value fulfillment theory privileges the long term and discounts what we might call "momentary well-being". This isn't quite accurate, though, because a life cannot be rich in value fulfillment without its having many moments in which values are being fulfilled. Still, the value fulfillment theory does have us evaluate choices in the moment with an eye to how they will contribute to the whole.

To some extent the focus on values makes this "whole life" or "overall" perspective inevitable, because values are not typically the kinds of things we can fulfill in the moment, nor the kind of thing we can weigh by looking at them in isolation. One can satisfy a desire for gustatory pleasure in an instant, but people who *value* gustatory pleasure must organize their lives so that they have opportunities for it that fit with the other things they do. Of course, what happens in the moment is important to many values too: you won't fulfill the value of gustatory pleasure if you turn down every opportunity to eat something tasty in the moment. The point is that attention to the long term, and to the overall shape of a life, is built into a theory $\hookrightarrow$ that focuses on values. For example, my Uncle Paul is an avid bird-watcher who keeps a list of birds and travels all over the U.S. at the drop of a hat to see a new bird that has been spotted somewhere. If you focus on individual moments of Paul's bird-watching—moments in which he sees or doesn't see a particular rare bird, buys a plane ticket, cleans his binoculars—it seems like a decent hobby, but there are a lot of costs (frustration when the rare bird gets away, airport security lines, and so on) that might come close to outweighing the benefits. But if you see birding in the context of his life as a whole, you begin to see what's so great about it for Paul. The value of a rare bird sighting for Paul is not exhausted by the experience (as it would be for a person like me who knows nothing about birds and has no list); the sighting has value beyond the momentary experience because of the larger

context of Paul's extended pursuit, which is shaped by the accumulation of knowledge about birds over time and the achievement of increasingly difficult goals (seeing rarer birds) over time.

p. 48 But is the "whole life" perspective a good thing? I think so. Indeed, I think it is part of our ordinary way of thinking about well-being, particularly in the context of thinking about how to improve people's lives. Start with the observation that things that seem good for us in the short term may not be good for us when seen from the long-term perspective (the point of view of overall well-being). This is true for many different theories of well-being. A second martini now may be good for me in the next twenty minutes, because of the pleasure it brings, but it may cause enough pain tomorrow that it isn't good for me when we take a longer-term perspective. Similarly, satisfying my desire for cake with buttercream frosting is good for me now, but not good for me in the long term if I am supposed to be on a low cholesterol diet. Value fulfillment also produces these disparities: I may value a friendship that provides short-term fun but isn't good for me in the long term because the friend is bad for my self-esteem; I may value a career path that pays well enough for me to enjoy short-term benefits, but that doesn't suit me very well and won't be fulfilling in the long term. In both cases, pursuing what I value now is good for me now, but not good for my life as a whole. These are simple and under-described examples, but I think the phenomenon should be familiar enough. Things are parallel in the context of helping others where we tend to think about people's *lives* going well or badly, better, or worse. We would not think it terribly helpful to give a person one great moment that ruins the rest of their life.

I do not mean to deny that it can be sensible to talk about doing well in the moment, and it is important that the value fulfillment theory allows for this. Well-being at a particular time is appropriate value fulfillment at that time. But notice that the focus on *appropriate* values builds in some future orientation, because better integration (among our values and among the psychological states that comprise them) makes these values easier to fulfill over time. So, even when we evaluate well-being in the moment, we have one eye on the future. I think this is appropriate when it comes to helping people, though precisely how we divide our attention between momentary and overall well-being will depend on the context.

p. 49 For the value fulfillment theory, overall well-being consists in total value fulfillment: the ultimate goal is a life as rich in value fulfillment as it could be. This raises some questions. How should we think about the value-fulfilled life, the life "as rich in value fulfillment as it could be"? Is there only one such life per person? What if a person does something that forever prevents them from achieving *that* life? Is such a person doomed to a sub-optimal life? I think we should think about the value-fulfilled life (from now on, my shorthand for "a life as rich in appropriate value fulfillment as it could be") in the following way. For any person at a time there is a set of values (or a few different sets) and standards of fulfillment for those values such that, were those values to be fulfilled according to those standards, that person would get the most value fulfillment overall.¹⁶ There may be more than one best set of values because value fulfillment is not fine-grained. You can trade a bit of this for a bit of that and not affect your total very much. You can lower your standards of success in one domain and raise them in another, and come out even in terms of value fulfillment. This means that it's very unlikely that there will be a unique set of values and one best (richest) life for each person at a time. Further, the life richest in value fulfillment for a person will change with time, as the person's circumstances, values, and standards of success evolve. This makes sense, and it reflects the fact that we would give quite different advice to the same person at age 20, 40, and 60. Finally, improvements are steps that take a person closer to the richest life (or one of the lives richest in value fulfillment). We may not know with certainty what these steps are, but we can make reasonable judgments about what brings a person closer to more value fulfillment by following the standards of improvement discussed earlier (integration of emotion, desire, and judgment, plus sustainability over time).¹⁷

The idea that what counts as a value-fulfilled life for a person will change as that person develops will raise some eyebrows. My reason for thinking of things this way is that the value fulfillment theory is a practical theory, aimed at giving guidance about how to make improvements to a person's well-being. If the value-fulfilled life is an unchanging ideal that could become completely unattainable from a person's current

position, then the theory isn't much use. There is a problem with my way of thinking, however, which is that the idea of what is "available" to a person is vague. But I don't think this problem is as serious as it would be if we were so adaptable that we could value almost anything in any way. (Though the powers of adaptation we do have create a serious problem that I consider in its own section, 3.4.) For most of us (as I've said before), our development, personalities, and environments constrain us to value fairly typical things. That said, I think we do have to tolerate some vagueness about what we could come to value and in what ways (this will be explained further later in this chapter). There is vagueness here because we simply can't know with certainty all the possibilities that are open to us in terms of what we value and how we understand the fulfillment of these values. But this uncertainty is an unavoidable feature of life.

p. 50 Some readers might find this explanation of the value-fulfilled life disappointingly imprecise. One way to try to remove the imprecision would be to adopt the *rational life plan view* according to which well-being is evaluated in a top-down manner rather than constructed out of bits of momentary fulfillment. On this way of thinking, the good for a person is to live a life in accordance with the plan that they ↵ would want their life to take were they to deliberate about it rationally. As John Rawls (1971, p. 408) elaborates the idea, "[t]he rational plan for a person determines his good" and a person's plan of life is rational if and only if: "(1) It is one of the plans that is consistent with the principles of rational choice when these are applied to all the relevant features of his situation, and (2) it is that plan among those meeting this condition which would be chosen by him with full deliberative rationality, that is, with full awareness of the relevant facts and after a careful consideration of the consequences". In other words, the best life plan is the one you would choose if you knew what you were doing. You are doing well at a particular moment if you are doing something that contributes to this plan.

According to the rational life plan view, then, the value of a part of a life is determined by its relationship to the whole; the bits cannot be assessed first and added up because we do not know how much each bit is worth without looking at the entire life. The rational life plan view adds precision, because it gives us a principle to identify the best life for each person. But there are some reasons to worry about the idea that value-fulfilled lives are just the lives we would choose if we were fully rational. First, there are good reasons to be suspicious that rational choice—choice made "with full awareness of the relevant facts and after a careful consideration of the consequences"—will by itself guarantee a life rich in value fulfillment. This suspicion is fueled by research showing that careful consideration of our reasons does not always lead us to make good choices.¹⁸ In the context of the value fulfillment theory, we can imagine this happening because values are comprised partly of emotional dispositions, and these emotions might be at odds with where reason leads us. Most people know someone who thinks extremely clearly and thoroughly, and yet who isn't really in touch with their feelings and therefore sometimes makes poor choices. Second, any choice you make among rational life plans will have to be made on the basis of the values that you have at the moment you choose. How else could you choose which life is better? But if that's the case, then the rational life plan view requires that we specify a particular point in time at which you have a ↵ determinate set of values to form the basis for choice. And then we need to know how to identify the standpoint from which a person is to make this rational choice of life plan.¹⁹ If I were to have chosen a plan for my life at the age of 21, it would have looked very different from the plan I would choose now. Now, things have already gone the way they've gone and some of the things that would have been in my 21-year-old self's plan are now ruled out of any plan that could make sense for me going forward. Moreover, I've learned things about myself that make it the case that some of the values highlighted by my 21-year-old plan would now be quite unsuited to me. Which standpoint should be privileged? Privileging any particular age —21, 30, 47, 85?—seems arbitrary.

According to the value fulfillment theory, the best life for a person is the one with the most value fulfillment and this is a broad and shifting target. It is a broad target because there is almost always more than one way for a person to live a value-fulfilled life. There are different ways of fulfilling our most basic, core values (like friendship, meaningful work, and felt happiness), different standards of success we can hold these values to, and different ways of prioritizing them that might lead to value-fulfilled lives that are different but equal. It's a

shifting target, because the point of view from which “most” is defined depends on the possibilities that are open to the person at the time. If you are wishing the best life for a baby in their crib,²⁰ there will be many possibilities for how the baby’s life could go that haven’t been closed off by steps they have already taken. If you’re asking how an adult friend could improve their life, the target will be narrower, because the first few decades of living will have shaped what is possible for them. The target also shifts as our values change in degrees of appropriateness: some values become better for us as we find ways of pursuing them compatibly with other important values, while other values may become less appropriate as it becomes clear that they cannot change to accommodate our other concerns. (I’ll say more about degrees of appropriateness at the beginning of Chapter 3.)

p. 52 The idea that there’s not a single, unique best life for each person is intuitive, but it could also create a big problem. If there are a number $\hookrightarrow$ of lives that are equally good, how can we identify a path forward? How do we know how to make things better if we don’t know precisely where we’re going?

To solve this problem we need to distinguish between two questions. One question is ontological; it has to do with what is the case: If there is more than one way to live a value-fulfilled life for a person, is there a fact of the matter about how that person should proceed? Is the idea of a value-fulfilled life determinate enough to give us any guidance? The answer to this question had better be “yes”, and I think that it is. There would be real trouble here if there were an infinite number of value-fulfilled lives for each person, or if value-fulfilled lives were so different from each other that mutually inconsistent courses of action constantly turned out to be equally good. But this is not how things are for us humans. People tend to care about certain things very deeply, they have fairly stable personalities, and they face consistent challenges. While it is true that a life in which I had two children and didn’t learn to sing probably would have resembled a value-fulfilled life just as much as my actual life (in which I have two dogs and take singing lessons), the life in which I became a Catholic nun or a hermit, given my personality, would not contain much fulfillment of appropriate values for me. While there may be many, many various lives in which I have *some* values and pursue them, the set of lives in which I successfully pursue emotionally, motivationally, and cognitively appropriate values together over the long term is likely to be much smaller and more homogeneous.

p. 53 My claim that there is a fact of the matter about the most value-fulfilled life available to a person, and therefore a fact of the matter about how that person could improve their situation, will raise further questions (at least for those who are curious about metaethics). First, if there are facts about value-fulfilled lives, does that mean that I have succeeded in reducing the normative notion of well-being to natural, psychological facts about what people value? Whether I have done this or not depends on what you think about the norms of appropriateness for values. If you think the idea of an appropriate value can be spelled out without using any value terms, then —yes!—I have $\hookrightarrow$ bridged the gap between facts and values. But I don’t think I have done this. I think that, ultimately, the norms of appropriateness cannot be fully articulated and applied without using more evaluative judgments to do so.²¹ For example, when we ask whether a combination of values can be pursued together over time we will need to think about an “acceptable” degree of conflict and a “reasonable” sacrifice, and what counts as “acceptable” or “reasonable” is not something that can be determined empirically.

The other question raised by the imprecise target is epistemological; it has to do with what we can know: Can we have reasonable beliefs about what to do if we cannot identify (even in principle) a unique goal for each person? This question will be the topic of Chapter 4 where we begin to put the value fulfillment theory to work. There, we’ll ask how we should go about forming beliefs, making choices, and devising plans about what to do for other people (and ourselves) given our limited knowledge. So, I’ll ask the reader to trust me that there is an answer to this question (though not a quick one) for now.

One might have a more specific concern about the value-fulfilled life. Doesn’t privileging the long term create problems for taking the subjective perspective seriously? What about those who want to live hard and die young, or those who are willing to sacrifice the long term for the sake of something important now? There are

people who value high-risk activities in the fullest sense. Of course, we all value things that include some risk to our longevity; just driving a car to get to work involves some risk. But then there are those who seem to have a greater discount rate for the future than the rest of us do—for example, free rock-climbers and other extreme sports enthusiasts, astronauts, and journalists who cover conflict in dangerous parts of the world. If our guiding theory of well-being privileges the overall value-fulfilled life, then won't such people be living worse lives despite the fact that they are doing what they love to do? Wouldn't taking such risks always be bad for a person?

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These worries are overblown. The value fulfillment theory tells us that we should pay attention to the shape of a whole life when we aim to help people, but this does not mean “the longer the better” and it doesn't mean that short-term gains are never worth the risk of a long-term sacrifice. The contribution of individual choices to the whole is relevant to their evaluation, but what counts as a good whole is partly determined by the values that a person has. Staying alive for an extra ten years would not be worth it for most of us if we had to sacrifice our loved ones in order to do it. The difference between most of us and the risk-tolerant climber or journalist is in what we value, what we would not be willing to sacrifice, and how these values are prioritized. Further, some people value risk itself, or they value dramatic peaks and valleys in their experiences. These values also figure into what counts as a life that has the most value fulfillment, and a good deal of variability in future-orientation can be accommodated by including them. Once we acknowledge this, we can see that many of the examples we might have in mind as problems for the value fulfillment theory are not really problems. For people who value risk-taking, or spontaneity, or novelty, appropriately and relatively steadily, these values are some of their standards for how to live.

Now, if I am cautious, unspontaneous, and afraid of novelty, then it will be difficult for me to help people who live by the motto “live hard, die young!” or “no risk, no reward”. It is difficult to know how to help someone whose values are different from our own, in part because when we don't share values (or we don't prioritize them in the same way) we may not know how to weigh competing values appropriately for that person. If you are the kind of person whose life would be completely impoverished by giving up mountain climbing, and I simply cannot understand this, then I'm unlikely to be very good at helping you achieve a value-fulfilled life. The relative weight of some values against threats to our long-term survival is just one example of the way in which there can be large individual variation in the shape that a value-fulfilled life takes for different people. We'll talk more about this problem and these kinds of cases in Chapters 4 and 5.

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One might also object that this emphasis on the long term leaves out people who will not, as a matter of fact, have long lives. What is good for a person who is going to die at 25 is likely to be quite different from what is good for a person who will live to be 83. The value fulfillment theory does not deny this. What counts as a person's whole life is however long that person actually lives. As far as the ontological question goes (the question about what the value-fulfilled life is for the person), it will be determined by the amount of time they have. The real problem here is epistemic. If we knew how long each person's life would be, we could plan accordingly and think about what values they can best fulfill in the time they have. The thing is, though, that we don't usually know this with much certainty at all. We will make mistakes, then, in assessing people's well-being, but these mistakes are inevitable given the limits of our knowledge. We can err on the side of giving the future too much weight, assuming we'll live to be 120 and sacrificing too much for our future selves. Or, we can err by putting too much weight on the possibility of disaster, living for the moment since tomorrow we may die! There is surely a range in the happy medium, but that range will move with more information (e.g., about terminal illnesses or giant meteors heading for the earth).

Privileging the long term makes sense of the practical perspective we have when we think about well-being. It fits with the kind of helpfulness we hope for in friendship, and with the nature of the values most of us have. Thinking about the long-term perspective introduces greater uncertainty, because we don't know the future, but this is a problem in life, not a problem with the value fulfillment theory.

2.4 Can Ultimate Values be Improved?

With the notion of a value-fulfilled life in hand, we can now return to the question of how our values can be improved. What critical perspective do we have on our actual values, according to the value fulfillment theory?

p. 56 When we ask whether a person's values contribute to a value-fulfilled life overall, we are, at least in part, appealing to instrumental ↪ rationality. The norm of instrumental reason—take the necessary and available means to your end, or give up pursuit of it—is used frequently to evaluate people's values, desires, or goals. For example, Peggy values having a partner with whom to share her life, and as a means to this valued end she desires to go to speed dating events in her town. If she hates speed dating and hasn't found a single suitable partner after many attempts, her instrumental desires can be criticized on the grounds that their satisfaction would not actually bring about the ends they are supposed to serve. If speed dating is a bad way for Peggy to find love, then the satisfaction of Peggy's desire to continue going to these events would not be good for her.

Criticisms of instrumental desires can take us pretty far in assessing well-being. The anorexia sufferer's desire for excessive weight loss is not an efficient means to feeling in control; the miser's desire for piles of money is not a good means to being loved; and the tyrant's desire for power over others is not a means to happiness. Such criticisms are available to the value fulfillment theory. Often our basic values are pretty good, but we are taking inappropriate means to them. We make friends (good thing) with people who threaten our self-respect (bad means).

We might wonder whether the value fulfillment theory gives us more than this. Does the value fulfillment theory allow us to critically evaluate the things we value for themselves? Does it allow us, in the words of a friend of mine, to ask whether our ladder is up against the right wall? I think it does, not by imposing objective standards to which our values must measure up, but by way of the idea of *appropriate values* that I've been describing.

p. 57 Consider some examples of values people have to one degree or other that intuitively seem bad for us. Some people value being thin, being loved by everyone, being perfect, wielding power over other people, being rich and famous, or being "the best". Often, people value these things instrumentally—as a means to happiness or security, say. But some people do value these things for their own sakes; that is, their attitudes toward thinness, power, or the like are stable, long-standing, and resistant to evidence that these values are not a ↪ means to something else they care about. Nevertheless, many people find these values questionable as constituents of well-being. When we confront people whose lives seem to be governed by the pursuit of money, fame, or power for its own sake we are inclined to ask whether money, fame, or power really deserve the position of ultimate values. Does the value fulfillment theory allow us to ask this question?

We can ask this question by applying our instrumental standard to the whole pattern of values our friend has. Even if being universally liked (or being "the best", or having great power) is an ultimate value, we can ask whether having that value contributes to or frustrates the fulfillment of other values and, therefore, whether its pursuit has a negative effect on overall value fulfillment. If pursuing this value would create less value fulfillment over time, if it would mean a life that is farther from the life richest in value fulfillment, then this is a value one is better off without.²² This way of looking at things still doesn't allow us to say that caring so much about being universally loved is just a mistake, whatever its effects on the pursuit of other values. Does the value fulfillment theory give us more to say?

There are other questions we can ask about our values if we follow the value fulfillment theory. These questions will vary with the context (more about this later), but they will include some versions of the following:

- Is this value appropriate to the person? Does it integrate emotion, desire, and judgment?

- Can the value in question really be fulfilled over time at all? Does the person have even an implicit standard for what would count as succeeding? (Status is a notoriously elusive value.)
- Is the value in question (perfection, money, power) really a stand-in for something else (say, friendship, achievement, or acceptance)? And if it is, would the person be better off in terms of value fulfillment if they could learn to construe the latter values in a different way?
- Are there values that the person does not have at the moment but that might be very important for a value-fulfilled life (such as the value of integrity or self-acceptance) that will be frustrated by the attempt to fulfill the value in question?

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Again, these questions do not allow us to say that a value is defective, period, as opposed to its being defective in virtue of the person's psychology, their other values, and the kind of life they are capable of living. But they do take us a fair way past simple questions about means to ends.

According to the value fulfillment theory, valuing being liked, famous, thin, powerful, and so on, should be assessed in terms of the role of these values in an ongoing system. If that role is uniformly negative, then there is nothing good about fulfilling those values. It is worth pointing out that *any* value can be subjected to this scrutiny, not just those values that are commonly condemned. I think that money, power, fame, and perfection are values that are more likely to have a largely negative effect on most people's systems of values than are the values of family, health, and meaningful work. But this is a contingent claim and individual results may vary. Here, as elsewhere, I'm talking to and about most people.

We can improve ultimate values, then, by appeal to other values in the system or by appeal to the overarching goal of a life as rich in value fulfillment as could be. Are these the only ways our values could be improved? Couldn't it be that sometimes more radical improvement would be good for a person? Philosophical research on "transformative experience" suggests this might be the case. A transformative experience is one that we cannot know what it's like to have without having already had it. Further, according to some philosophers, it is an experience we cannot choose to have on the basis of the values we have now. For example, Laurie Paul (2014) argues that when we confront the option of a transformative experience we cannot use our current values to assess whether we would be better off having the experience, because we cannot know what it will be like to be the transformed person. Paul gives the example of having children. The experience of "gestating, producing, and becoming attached to that child" is epistemically transformative because the experience changes what you know about what it is like to have a child (pp. 77–8).

- p. 59 If there are genuinely transformative experiences, does that show that we need other ways of thinking about how to improve our values besides the ones that the value fulfillment theory admits? You might think so. After all, as discussed in the previous section, the idea of a value-fulfilled life is tied to the person whose life it is; it is not defined as a life that *would* work for a radically transformed person.

Ultimately, however, I agree with Ruth Chang that these epistemically transformative experiences do not provide an insurmountable challenge to the view that we improve our future values based on our current values or our current selves.²³ Chang (2015) argues, first, that not many experiences are truly epistemically transformative, because few experiences engage basic capacities that we have not experienced engaging before. Having children, for instance, involves basic human sensory, emotional, and rational capacities. It employs these capacities in new ways, but it does not represent something that has absolutely no connection to previous experiences, and we can narrow the gap by exercising our imaginations and talking to others who know more than we do. Second, Chang argues that the subjective experience of having a child (or of any potentially transformative experience) is not the only basis we have for choosing to have it or not. We can also choose based on objective considerations: "having a child will objectively enrich your life in significant ways, be instrumental in bringing a valuable human life into the world, help create in the world a loving family bond between you and your spouse, etc. On the basis of these objective values of the experience, you can know that

the experience of having a child will be better than, say, the experience of being skinned alive” (Chang 2015, pp. 256–7). For my purposes, the point here is that even if a person does not know exactly what the subjective experience of having a child would be like, she can know enough about the value of having children to make a reasonable judgment about whether a value-fulfilled life for her would include being a parent. This is not to say that this assessment would be easy to make, nor that the person couldn’t make a mistake; it is just that we don’t require an additional criterion for the improvement of values.

p. 60 But we’re not done yet. In her discussion of transformative experiences, Chang introduces a different kind of case—the case of “choice-based transformative choices”. When you make this kind of choice, “you change who you are by the very making of a choice, not by some experience or event downstream from your choice” (p. 239). This kind of choice is possible when we are choosing between options that are “on a par”, that is, where one option is not better than the other, but they are also not equal in value. It may be difficult to grasp what is meant by “on a par” if it doesn’t mean “equal”. The intuitive idea, it seems to me, is that two options are on a par when they have different kinds of value that aren’t on the same scale. Many choices in life seem to be like this. Decisions about whether to maintain long-distance friendships or concentrate on the friends who live nearby, to pursue a clinical practice or focus on research, to be a parent or to put more energy into your career, and so on, are often decisions where neither option is better overall than the other—things can work out well, though differently, either way. Why not say that these options are actually equal in value? Well, Chang points out that if a pair of options were truly equivalent in value, then if you added a tiny bit of goodness to one, it would make it *better*. But this isn’t how we think about options like the ones I’ve just mentioned. If I see being a parent and not being a parent as on a par, and you tell me that I can be a parent and have an extra piece of cheesecake (certainly a good thing as far as I’m concerned), will that make the life in which I’m a parent better? This seems wrong. It would also seem wrong to flip a coin to decide—but if the options were truly equal in value, this would be a rational strategy. The message is that there isn’t a single scale on which to weigh the value of these different lives that could establish that they weigh the same amount. Nevertheless, Chang does not think on a par options are incomparable, if that means that we cannot choose between them. We can, and when we do so we create reasons for ourselves and determine the kind of person that we will become.

p. 61 Chang’s idea that options can be on a par is compelling (though it is also controversial in philosophy: Andreou 2015; Williams 2016). Does it create problems for the value fulfillment theory? If options ↴ can be on a par, and if we change who we are by choosing between such options, there would be greater indeterminacy about what counts as a value-fulfilled life for a person. After all, if value-fulfilled lives are anchored to the person and the person is in flux, then the life that is best for a person—the target—will also be in flux. Notice, however, that the flux isn’t (typically) *radical*. For one thing, our personalities are usually stable enough that radical transformations in our appropriate values are unlikely (Briley and Tucker-Drob 2014; Ferguson 2010). When options are on a par, by definition, one is not better than another. The life in which I’m a parent is not going to be on a par with the life in which I become an axe murderer or a hermit. Also, the flux does not mean we cannot make decisions or take action. What does the value fulfillment theory say we should do about options that seem to be on a par? We should think about our values and the various ways in which our lives could move closer to a life very rich in value fulfillment. We should make sure they really are on par and that we’re not just missing something, and we should consider whether there’s some third option that’s better than the two that are on a par. Then we should choose. If the options really are on a par (and there’s no option better than both), then we’ll do well whichever way we go.

2.5 Value Fulfillment Theory: Subjective or Objective?

Discussions of well-being in philosophy often divide theories of well-being into two camps: subjective theories and objective theories. According to one way of drawing this distinction, subjective theories say that whether or not something contributes to a person's well-being always depends on that person's attitudes (Sumner 1996). A person must like (or be disposed to like under certain conditions), want, value, or have some other subjective response to any candidate component of well-being for it to be good for them. Objective theories, on the other hand, deny this. These theories say that something $\hookrightarrow$ could be good for a person even if they don't like, want, or value it (or have any other subjective response toward the thing). The value fulfillment theory says that something could be valuable for a person who doesn't currently value that thing, because it could be that a certain value (for example, health or self-respect) is needed for that person to live a value-fulfilled life. But the value fulfillment theory still holds that if the person could not ever value this thing—if it could never be one of their values in any improved version of their life—then it is not good for that person. In this way, the value fulfillment theory preserves the grain of truth in subjectivism that for something to be good *for me* it has to be something that I can see as good for me.

The fact that the value fulfillment theory posits an ideal that is independent of a particular person's subjective responses—that is, the value-fulfilled life—might make it seem like an objective theory. Indeed, the value fulfillment theory has in common with objective theories that it does make room for a critical perspective on a person's actual values. We have this critical perspective because there are norms for the improvement of a person's values that reach beyond that person's current psychological states. First, the goal of living a value-fulfilled life imposes a standard of sustainability on a person's values. For example, a person who values partying with hard drugs and lots of alcohol is not doing as well as they could if these values are going to cause an early death and the forfeiture of many other things they would come to value more. Second, the social context in which we pursue many of our values imposes constraints on the standards for what counts as fulfilling a value. For example, someone who values being a father cannot simply make up what it is to succeed in terms of this value. An impatient and neglectful father is not doing well at being a father. I'll say more about these standards for what counts as fulfilling a value in the next chapter. For now the important point is that the value fulfillment theory does not simply take a person's actual values as a given; rather, it allows for the possibility that a person would be better off making changes to their values.

This does not make the value fulfillment theory an objective theory, however, in an important sense. The value fulfillment theory $\hookrightarrow$ says that a fruitful way to think about well-being, in the context of helping other people, is to think about what is good for people as anchored by their values and guided by the ways in which their values could be improved. The theory rejects the idea that certain things are good for people entirely independently of how they feel about them or could come to feel about them. In this respect (an important respect, I think) the value fulfillment theory is not an objective theory.

Moreover, the value fulfillment theory does not constrain which values can be part of a value-fulfilled life in the way that an objective theory would. For example, the value fulfillment theory implies (in contrast to objective theories) that it is at least possible for a Mafioso with a stable set of values that fit his personality to achieve well-being even though his values are morally questionable. (Though the value fulfillment theory certainly doesn't imply that it's easy for the immoral person to achieve well-being.) This implication—that someone could achieve well-being by pursuing morally bad goals, or satisfying morally bad desires—is usually thought to be a serious problem for subjective theories. I think the problem is a problem with the world: what's good for one isn't always good for all. And if this is a problem with the world, I think we're better off facing it squarely than trying to define it out of existence. (This topic will come up again in Section 5.2 where we'll consider whether being a helpful friend requires you to help a friend pursue values that you find morally objectionable. To anticipate, I think the answer is "definitely not". My point here is just that this implication about the possibility of a happy villain reveals the subjective commitments of the value fulfillment theory.)

p. 64

To my mind the most plausible candidate for an objective value is, somewhat paradoxically, psychological happiness. Dan Haybron argues that well-being consists in the fulfillment of a person's individual nature, which in turn requires emotional fulfillment in the form of happiness, and rational fulfillment in the form of the successful pursuit of values (Haybron 2008a). Happiness, according to Haybron's theory, is a favorable emotional condition, which includes ↪ three types of positive emotional state: endorsement, engagement, and attunement (2008b). Obviously these are subjective psychological states, but Haybron takes them to be good for people independently of their own choices or attitudes toward these psychological states. To put it quickly: You don't have to want to be happy for happiness to be good for you. I think it is extremely plausible that these positive emotional states are good for everyone, so why not say that emotional happiness is an objective value? First, notice that the distinction between subjectivism and objectivism starts to break down here, when it comes to the value of emotional happiness. This is because to value something is partly to be disposed to have certain kinds of positive emotions, and, therefore, the positive emotional states that constitute your happiness are going to be interwoven with your values. For example, feelings of engagement or flow when you play basketball are one component of valuing basketball. The feelings of attunement you feel when you are in nature are part of what it is to value nature. Because of this overlap, value fulfillment will naturally and inevitably coincide with the pursuit of emotional happiness. So, I don't think much is to be gained from treating emotional happiness as the sole objective value. Second, when there are choices to be made—for example, the choice of how to prioritize the different emotional components of happiness, or how to compare happiness to other ultimate values—I maintain that what determines which path is best for a person depends on how that person is able to integrate their emotions, desires, and judgments.²⁴

I am a subjectivist at heart, though the value fulfillment theory has moved away from any simple form of subjectivism. That said, allow me to repeat a point from the introduction, which is that thinking about how value fulfillment works is not just for subjectivists. Any theory of well-being should recognize the importance of successfully doing things that matter to us, and understanding how to help the people we care about to do so as well. Readers who think there are objective prudential values can think of the value-fulfilled lives posited by the value fulfillment theory as constrained by these objective facts.

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2.6 Conclusion

We are looking for a theory of well-being that addresses our practical concern for helping people to improve their lives. We need an understanding of well-being that does not make well-being something alien to the people we're trying to help, but that also gives us some legitimate grounds for questioning a person's current perspective on what is good for them when it seems very much at odds with what we think is good for them. I hope this chapter has established how the value fulfillment theory promises to do this. It defines well-being in terms of a person's individual psychology, namely, that person's values. But it also allows for the possibility that a person's values are in need of improvement or transformation (thus allowing for the possibility of error) and provides standards for improvement that preserve the close tie between well-being and the subject.

To recap, the value fulfillment theory says that well-being is the fulfillment of appropriate values over a lifetime. Appropriate values integrate our emotions, desires, and judgments about what makes our lives go well and what we have reason to do. Fully appropriate values are also ones that we can pursue and achieve together over time. Appropriate values, then, are (1) suited to our desires and emotions, (2) reflectively endorsed, and (3) capable of being fulfilled together over time.

Of course, as we have already observed, these guidelines leave room for many different ways of living a life in which you value and enjoy good friendships, meaningful work, pleasurable experiences, and so on. There are, in other words, many different shapes that the value-fulfilled life can take and if our theory is going to guide us

in how to help people it will also have to direct our thinking about the details. This leads us directly to the application of the value fulfillment theory, which is the subject of the rest of the book.

Notes

1. I use different verbs to talk about the fulfillment of values: we fulfill, realize, achieve, or succeed in terms of our values. This is intentional; as we'll see, what counts as value fulfillment (and therefore which verb is appropriate) depends on the value and how it is understood by the person whose value it is.
2. To those familiar with debates in metaethics, the terms "cognitive" and "judgment" will raise questions about the status of the normative judgments involved in valuing; for an overview of the relevant debate, see van Roojen 2016. The value fulfillment theory is not a metaethical theory; it is intended to be neutral about how best to understand the semantics and the psychology of normative judgments.
3. Connie Rosati argues that fittingness is the defining feature of the property of the personal good: something that is good for a person *fits* her (Rosati 2006). Rosati is developing a metaethical theory of well-being, so she and I put the notion of 'fit' to somewhat different uses, but I have been influenced by her work here.
4. For an illuminating discussion of caring, see Jaworska 2007.
5. Notice that these affective patterns are likely to include dispositions to experience some negative emotions (such as shame) when the value in question is at risk.
6. I want to leave open that these judgments about reasons could be given an expressivist interpretation, though I'm not assuming this here. For a defense of expressivist semantics about reason judgments, see Gibbard 1992. See also footnote 2.
7. The language of "reflective endorsement" is often associated with Kantian theories according to which reflection leads us to acknowledge that we are bound by reason to value our rational nature, or to follow certain rational principles. I don't follow this Kantian path, but I like the language of reflective endorsement because it suggests thinking things through and making a commitment on the basis of reasons. I explore what counts as reflection in detail in my 2008.
8. There is some evidence for this in the research on personal projects, which I mentioned in Chapter 1. According to this research, personal projects that include both affective and cognitive components are more likely to be successful and also more likely to promote happiness (life satisfaction and positive affect), which is a core value for most people (Little, Salmela-Aro, and Phillips 2007).
9. This is true for normal adult human beings, anyway. If we want to talk about the values of animals or humans with diminished cognitive capacities, we should focus on their affective and motivational orientation. (And in some such cases it may make more sense to talk about their cares, concerns, or attachments.) More about such cases in Section 4.5.
10. For more on this account of valuing and values, see my 2000, 2008. The precise way I have delineated the features of values has changed over the years, but the basic pictures of values as involving emotions, desires, and judgments that form relatively stable patterns has remained the same. For sympathetic treatments, see Anderson 1995; Raibley 2010; Schmuck and Sheldon 2001.
11. This is roughly Chris Heathwood's 2011 solution to the problem on behalf of desire satisfactionism.
12. Intrinsic disvalues, often partly constituted by aversion, may have a special role to play in ill-being. On the distinct importance of aversion, see Arpaly and Schroeder 2013.
13. In my 2008, I argued that life satisfaction and self-direction are two values that are presupposed by anyone who is committed to living a life that is good from her own point of view. I'm still convinced by this argument, but I don't count on it here.
14. In philosophical terminology we could say that the focus on values helps explain the normativity of well-being.
15. Notice that many of the unintuitive implications of desire theories stem from the fact that we do not take all of our desires to give us reasons that justify action. But values just are those patterns of attitudes that we take to be reason-giving, so a value-based theory of well-being will not have this problem. Also, note that Sumner understands life satisfaction as comprising an affective and a cognitive response, unlike psychologists who think of life satisfaction as a global cognitive appraisal (Diener, Scollon, and Lucas 2003). This may put Sumner's view on better footing with respect to this point.
16. I take value fulfillment to be additive (Bradley 2009), which means that overall value fulfillment is determined by adding up individual moments or components of value fulfillment. An alternative to this is the *holisticparadigm-resemblance view* defended by Jason Raibley 2012. According to this holistic approach, momentary bits of well-being (individual moments of value fulfillment) contribute to overall well-being insofar as they make for greater resemblance to a paradigmatically well-lived life. A person achieves well-being to the degree that she resembles the paradigm of the flourishing agent and, as Raibley (2010, p. 596) puts it, "[i]n order to resemble this paradigm, a person must (a) have values, as opposed to mere

desires or enjoyments, (b) actively realize these values, and (c) maintain the physical and psychological attributes that are the causal basis for the disposition to succeed". I am tempted by Raibley's holism and I have learned a tremendous amount from his work, but I think that the notion of a paradigm introduces unnecessary complexity to an already fairly complex theory.

17. Note that the goal of a value-fulfilled life (the life, or set of lives, richest in value fulfillment) is an aspirational goal, an ideal. We can live very well without achieving the greatest value fulfillment.
18. See Haidt 2006; Haybron 2008b; Wilson 2002. I have discussed this research in detail in my 2008 and 2013.
19. This is one of the reasons Raibley 2012 rejects the rational life plan view.
20. On the "crib test", as Fred Feldman has called it, see Feldman 2010. See Kraut 1979 for a different perspective on a similar thought experiment.
21. I gravitate toward a *constructivist* construal of these norms, rather than a *reductive* construal. See my 2012, 2017.
22. Actual desire satisfaction theories can say the same thing about ultimate desires. An ultimate desire is defective, for desire satisfactionism, if it will prevent more satisfaction in the future than it will produce now; it is not intrinsically defective (Heathwood 2005).
23. Chang has a different target. She aims to show that epistemically transformative experiences do not undermine standard approaches to rational choice according to which we choose rationally on the basis of the value of the options. But her arguments work well for my purposes, too.
24. Proving that this is the best way to think about the value of happiness would take us deep into metaethics, which would be quite a diversion. The divide between subjectivism and objectivism about value in metaethics is deep and long-standing, and I don't think it really matters for the conversation about happiness and well-being. Ultimately, it's difficult to imagine a person for whom their own happiness is not an appropriate value, especially when we see that the emotional states that comprise happiness are themselves valuing attitudes.